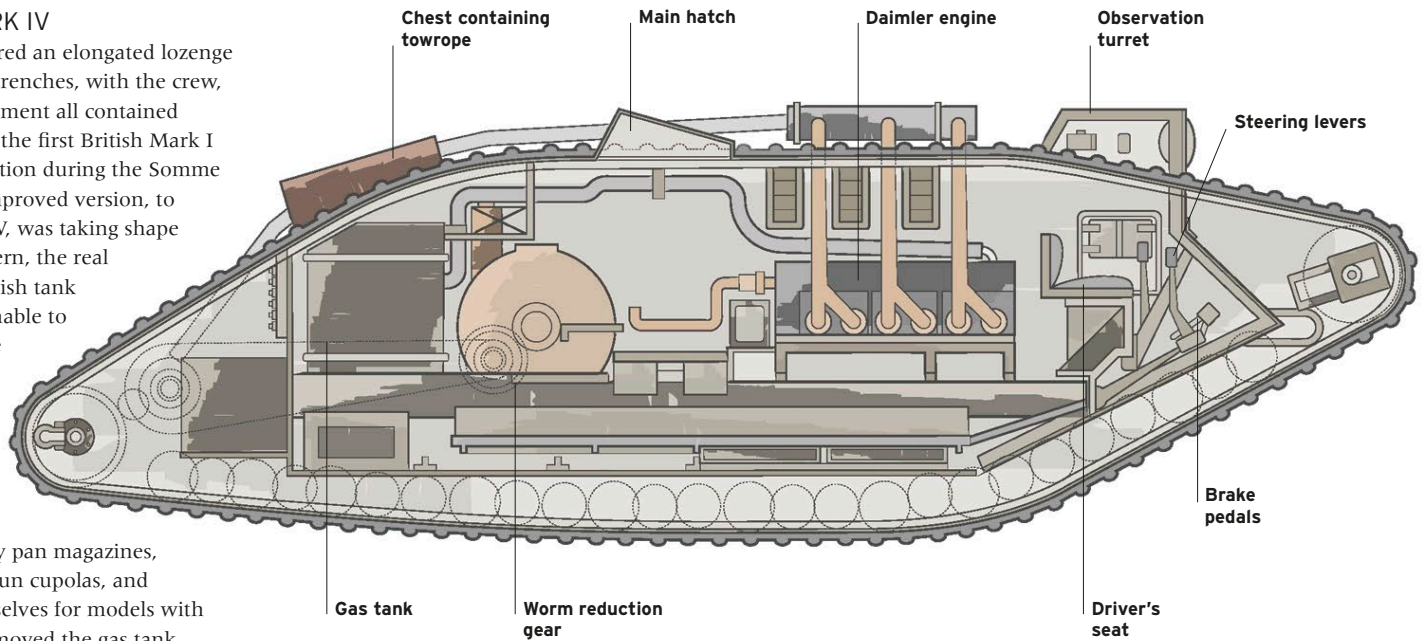


EARLY DESIGN: MARK IV

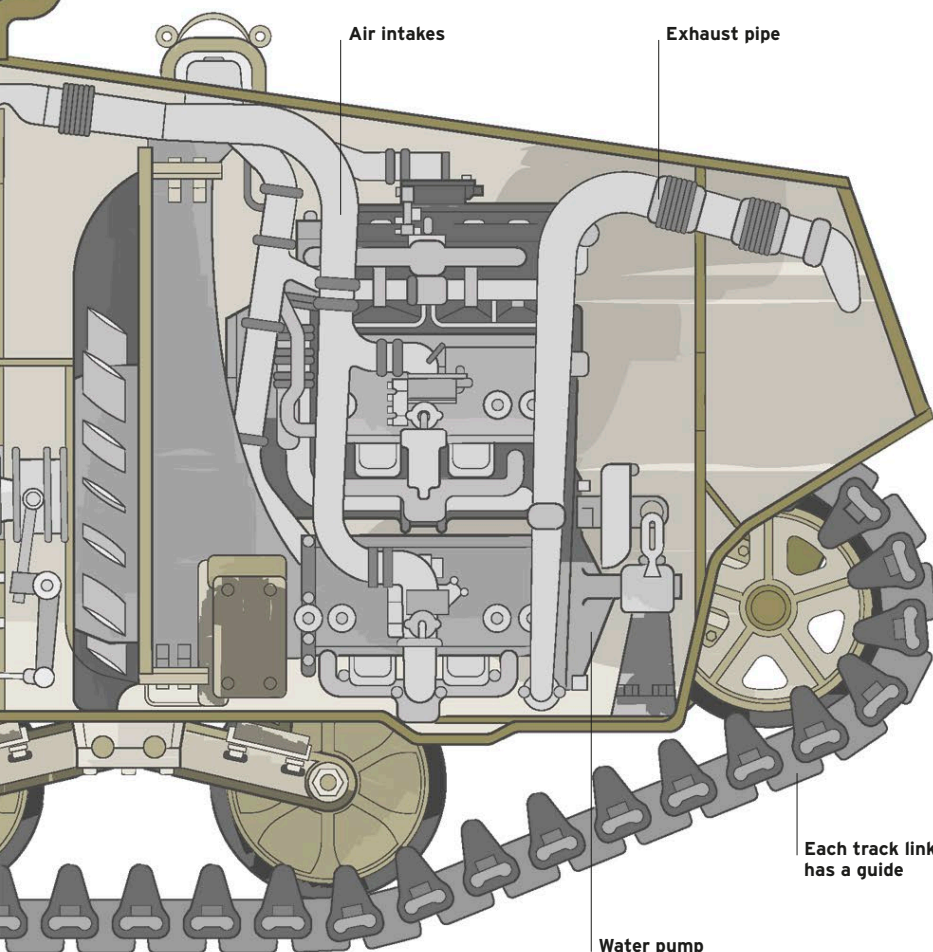
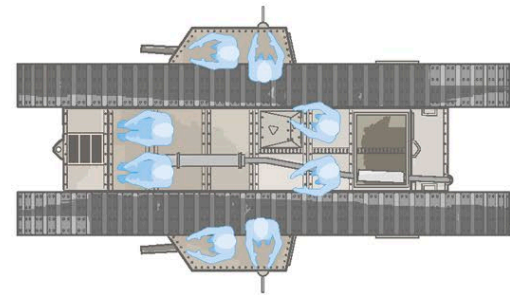
Early British tanks featured an elongated lozenge shape designed to cross trenches, with the crew, tracks, engine, and armament all contained within the hull. Even as the first British Mark I tanks were going into action during the Somme campaign of 1916, an improved version, to be known as the Mark IV, was taking shape in the mind of Albert Stern, the real driving force behind British tank development. He was unable to change the engine, as he wanted, but specified improved armor and ventilation, exchanged the strip-fed Hotchkiss machine guns for Lewis guns with larger-capacity pan magazines, reduced the size of the gun cupolas, and swapped the guns themselves for models with shorter barrels. He also moved the gas tank outside the vehicle, between the tracks.

Simultaneously, tacticians such as General Elles and Colonel Fuller were working on new ways of employing the tank. The revised vehicle's first outings, on the Ypres salient, were imperfect, but at Cambrai, on November 20, 1917, the attack breached the German frontline across a front 6 miles (9.7 km) wide. Although the attack was ultimately unsuccessful, it established the basic principle of armored warfare.



Manning the Mark IV

In addition to the commander and the driver, two men were required to engage and disengage the gearboxes, and thus steer the vehicle by means of its tracks. Two more manned the 6-pounder guns, and another pair acted as loaders for the 6-pounders and also manned the sponson-mounted machine guns.



CLASSIC DESIGN: M4A4 SHERMAN

The M4A4 demonstrated the layout that would become the norm for tank design for decades—the main armament in a rotating turret, a rear-mounted engine, and angled hull armor. One of the many subtypes of the M4, the M4A4, known to the British as the Sherman V, was characterized by its Chrysler A57 Multibank engine. A total of 7,499 were produced, and virtually all of them were operated by the British Army, many as Sherman VC Fireflies, with the 17-pounder gun installed in place of the original 75 mm and the machine gunner's position sacrificed to allow more ammunition to be stowed. In all, 49,234 M4 gun tanks were produced (and many more chassis were completed in other forms, such as engineering vehicles); examples were still in service many years after the end of World War II.

Manning the M4

As designed, the M4 had a crew of five: the commander, the gunner, and the loader—located in the turret, with the commander directly below the access hatch, behind and raised above the others—and the driver and the machine gunner in the bow of the vehicle, to port and starboard respectively.

